

Why Should We Fast?

In a moment we are going to pray and pass in review, but let me give you a little more preparation.

If you never do anything with what we preach this week, nothing, and all you do is come and warm a chair on Sundays and Wednesdays while remaining indifferent to the multitudes going to hell, your salvation is sure if you are born again. It is not by works, lest any man should boast. It was unearnable, unmeritable, and you certainly did not deserve His grace. Yet because of His blood, you have what you could not earn: His righteousness.

You are going to heaven, my friend, if you are born again.

But the question is: what are you taking with you?

Scripture says every man's work will be tried, and that day shall declare what sort it is. It will be tried by fire, a purger's fire, a refiner's fire, the kind that burns the dross and causes it to float to the top so it can be scooped off, leaving what is pure.

One day we will stand before Jesus, and He said that day shall declare it. If anything you have wrought abides after the trial by fire, anything built on gold, silver, precious stones rather than wood, hay, and stubble, then you will be rewarded according to what is left and not punished for what was burned.

Your failures have already been laid upon the Lord Jesus Christ. You will not be punished for them. He said you will be saved as by fire. If you have no reward, your works will burn, but you yourself will be saved.

That is why He went on to say, "You are the temple of God," and "If any man defile the temple of God, him shall God destroy." He was not talking about you drinking, smoking, chewing, and defiling your body, as though He were saying, "Buddy, you are dead."

He was talking about the building of God. You are one of those lively stones, and if you falsely build that building through false doctrine or wrong motivation, your works will be destroyed. If you defile His temple, your works will be destroyed, but you yourself will be saved.

So as we enter in tonight, you will not be any worse off if you never do anything with what we have preached this week. Some of you are looking at me with uncertainty. You are thinking, If I leave, will I be safe?

We probably should go beyond prayer. We probably should go into intercession. Do not let me scare you.

Go to Matthew 17. We will begin with verse 14 and take this a step further into peace. We are talking about walking all the way into peace.

If you had asked me, "Brother Roberson, are you walking in peace?" I would have said, "Does a dog in Oklahoma have fleas? I am a faith man. What do you mean, am I walking in peace?"

That is because I did not have now to compare with then.

After sixteen years of ministry, after entering into God and seeking everything, after seeking to grow close to Him, somewhere along the line He diverted me and said, "As you love one another, My love is perfected in you." He began to sharpen, hone, and reveal the love of God to me. Then He brought me into a room of peace.

At a time when I was supposed to be burning out, I never knew a place like this in Christ Jesus could exist. I never knew God could talk so much. All I have to do is enter that room, and He starts talking. I go through verses, and I never knew His voice was so loud.

It is the most tremendous place I have ever been, and I would not trade it for anything.

Tonight we are going to take another step out of every double-minded thing Jesus said you are free from. One more step into peace and purpose, just because you want to.

Jesus was on what we call the Mount of Transfiguration. He left nine of His disciples at the foot of the mountain and took Peter, James, and John up with Him, where He had a visitation. Moses and Elijah appeared to Him. Peter, James, and John saw Jesus' face shine as the sun and His clothing become white as light. They got beside themselves.

After it was over, Jesus charged them to tell no man. Then He came down from the mountain to where the nine disciples had been left.

Evidently there was the father of a demon-possessed boy there. Nothing can get to the heart of a father faster. This father had heard the fame of Jesus and had heard that Jesus and His disciples cast out devils. So he came to the nine.

When the father met Jesus, he threw himself down and said, "I besought Thy disciples, and they could not cure him." They had tried so long to cure the boy that they had begun to draw quite a crowd. A multitude was gathering around them because they were putting on such a show.

This is what Jesus walked into in Matthew 17:14-18:

"And when they were come to the multitude, there came to him a certain man, kneeling down to him, and saying,
Lord, have mercy on my son: for he is lunatic, and sore vexed: for oftentimes he falleth into the fire, and oft into the water.
And I brought him to thy disciples, and they could not cure him.
Then Jesus answered and said, O faithless and perverse generation, how long shall I be with you? how long shall I suffer you? bring him hither to me.
And Jesus rebuked the devil; and he departed out of him: and the child was cured from that very hour."

Then verse 19 says:

"Then came the disciples to Jesus apart, and said, Why could not we cast him out?"

They came to Him apart. Privately. They said, "Why could we not cast him out?"

Verse 20 says:

"And Jesus said unto them, Because of your unbelief: for verily I say unto you, If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you."

What kind of verse is this?

"And nothing shall be impossible unto you."

Now what are we going to do with a verse like that? Continue to sit in religious circles and admire it?

What are we going to do with verses like, "The works that I do shall he do also; and greater works than these shall he do, because I go unto My Father"? What are we going to do with verses like, "You can say to this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place," and if you doubt not in your heart, you will have what you say?

My God, I have admired verses like that as long as I can remember. But to be quite frank, these verses were never very close to me. They were something you shifted into a kind of no-man's land. You could admire them and preach them, and they could make the hair stand up on the back of your neck. But when it came to reality, hardly anybody could claim them.

Yet Jesus had the audacity to say, "Nothing shall be impossible unto you."

This was not written only for the twelve apostles. It was not written only for their generation, or the first century, or the fourth, fifth, twelfth, sixteenth, eighteenth, or nineteenth. These verses were written for any child of God, anywhere, even in a back alley of Calcutta, India, who picked them up and read them.

As I entered this room of peace and became saturated by the Lord Jesus Christ, some of the first realities that hit me, when He began to bathe me in His love, were in Him. Not very much in religion, but in Him. For the first time in my life, even though it was still a little far away, I began to sense a reality moving toward me. I saw the possibility of that verse:

"Nothing shall be impossible unto you."

If Jesus had yelled over the head of a crowd, "You perverse and backward generation, how long am I going to have to cast devils out for you?" do you think I would have yelled back, "Well, why could I not cast it out?"

He would have yelled back, "Roberson! Because of your unbelief!"

So I would have done the same thing the disciples did. I would have pulled Him aside privately. He has a way of answering your question. Ask publicly, and He answers publicly. Ask privately, and He answers privately.

They wanted to know privately. After He had called them backward and perverse, they would rather keep it between Him and them, especially if they were His mighty staff that had just failed.

He got them privately and said, "Because of your unbelief."

My God, something went off on the inside of me. The Holy Ghost began to bring revelation to my spirit. I knew that if I could ever isolate and identify this particular kind of unbelief and eradicate it, I would become one of those to whom He said, "Absolutely nothing shall be impossible to you."

Do you think I did not pull that chapter out, pitch a tent, drive down the stakes, and start camping? I wanted to know what kind of unbelief He was talking about. It must be some super kind of unbelief, the most subtle and deceptive kind imaginable, because the opposite of it is, "Nothing shall be impossible to him that believeth."

If I could isolate that particular kind of unbelief, I thought I would be looking right into the face of Satan himself.

As He began opening this up, I realized it must be one of the most subtle kinds of unbelief imaginable, the kind religion lives in. Most of the time we do not even know we have it because we have consented to accept things the way they are instead of bringing change by impossible verses such as, "Nothing shall be impossible to you."

If you had asked me whether a man could pastor a church of seven hundred thousand, I would have said no. But Yonggi Cho said yes.

It must be the subtlest kind, the kind a person does not even know he has. Why would the disciples ask, "Why could we not cast him out?" if they already knew why? They asked because they did not know.

Do you think they did not turn themselves inside out when they prayed for that boy? They did not know why the devil would not come out. That is why they asked.

Jesus said, "Because of your unbelief."

One of the first steps to revival in your personal life is to refuse to accept things the way they are. If Jesus said it is because of unbelief, then it is because of unbelief.

When I asked Him to give me a comparison, this unfolded in my spirit.

Suppose there were children in wheelchairs over in the corner, ages three to six, so we cannot shift responsibility onto them. Twenty little children with every deformity: demonized, deformed, out of touch with reality.

My little Tani, my little girl whom I nicknamed Jabberjaws, has four brothers. Her oldest brother is twenty-two. I can testify that little Jabberjaws has already said more in her short four years than all the rest of them put together.

Her body is so active that I believe it moves at the speed of thought. I never had a little girl before. They are different. She jumps up on my lap, pulls the fat on my face, and says, "Daddy, Daddy," then asks five questions before I can get five words out answering the first one. Her mind shifts, and suddenly she is across the room picking up a toy and dancing around, then running back again. Four-year-old spirits are so active.

I cannot even begin to conceive it. It has hurt me badly over the years to see children ages three to six imprisoned in bodies that cannot respond, while their little spirits are just as active as my little Tani's. They cannot do anything about it. I have seen those children turn inward and bang their heads if that was the only part of them that would move.

Do you think I would go over into that wheelchair section and lay hands on those little children without reaching inside myself and turning everything in there inside out? Do you not think I would pull for every fiber and ounce of faith in me to see them healed?

What if I reached inside and pulled everything out, and not one of them jumped up out of the chair? Then I walked away and said, "I do not know. I do not know why."

Then the door opened, and Jesus walked in in His glorified body, stood behind the pulpit, and gave me a chance to ask any question I wanted. I would ask Him the same thing they asked:

"Jesus, when I went over there and laid hands on those twenty children, it just was not Your will to heal them, was it?"

He would say, "I will show you My will." Then He would walk over and empty the wheelchairs.

Then I would say, "If it was Your will to heal them, I want to know one thing, Jesus. Why could I not cast them out? Did You not want to heal them through me?"

"Yes."

"Then why could I not cast them out?"

He would look me straight in the eye and give me the same answer He gave them. Are you man enough to take it?

He would say, "Because of your unbelief."

But I know this about my Jesus: He will never outline a problem without outlining an answer. When it dawned on me that He would tell me in person the same thing He told them that day, I realized we must be missing something.

So I pitched my tent and moved in on that chapter until I could understand the subtle kind of unbelief He was talking about and take the first step toward eradicating it.

If you can deal with it, He said nothing, absolutely nothing, would be impossible to you. I did not write this. This is the Word of God. Nothing. Even the winning of a city.

As I meditated on this, He summed it up and showed me where I had been in error and why I kept missing it.

Matthew 17:21 says:

"Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting."

"Howbeit" is an analytical word. Jesus analyzed the whole situation: their unbelief, their use of faith, and their attempt to use faith. He analyzed all of it and said, "This kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting."

The prayer He was talking about could not be the prayer they uttered over the demon-possessed boy. That prayer did not work. He had to be talking about a lifestyle.

Then He added something we faith people did not know much about: fasting.

Some teachers consented to fasting enough to say it was probably necessary for Roberson's ministry because Roberson dealt in demon deliverance. Not the bucket-foaming kind. The real stuff.

In Brazil, when three thousand preachers were there, one girl from one of the families was demon-possessed. She looked normal. I wondered why God said, "Lay your hand on her." I reached up to touch her. She threw her arm up, dove under the chairs, and started crawling through the preachers while they got out of the way.

I jumped on the back of a chair, intercepted her when she came out, and said, "Come out!" She went dead still. Some started toward her, and I said, "Leave her alone. He is coming out."

She lay there like she was dead for forty-five minutes. Bernard Stalgrave said that when I reached up to touch that girl, that devil threw her arm up and her eyes shrieked with horror and terror as he threw her under the chairs.

It did not do any good. The devil came out.

Then she wanted to hug me and Bernard. Talk about a tender moment. She hugged both of us, totally set free. We did not even need any buckets.

Some say, "You have a deliverance ministry. You need fasting because there are big devils out there that will not come out unless you fast."

But Jesus did not equate fasting only to the deliverance of that demon-possessed boy. He equated it to the moving of your mountain. The next verse says that if you had faith as a grain of mustard seed, you could say to this mountain, "Remove hence to yonder place," and it would obey you. Nothing would be impossible to you.

Jesus equated fasting to moving your mountain: the thing resisting you, the thing that has kept your life like it has been for the last five years and will keep it that way for the next five unless you break the ceiling.

What makes it so sad is that some of us do not even care.

Fasting has absolutely nothing to do with moving God, and it has even less to do with the devil.

Someone says, "I am going to fast until it moves God."

You silly child. He set Himself in motion concerning your covenant two thousand years ago. He delights in charging into your life. He delights in answering your prayer. It is His pleasure to give you keys to the kingdom that unlock tremendous things in redemption. He pleasures in it. He loves it. It makes His day. He is your Father.

What do you mean, you moved Him?

Fasting does not move God. He is not the One stuck.

When the Israelites fasted so their voice might be heard on high, it did not work. But fasting will move you into a place where you can hear His voice on low.

Someone says, "I fasted for seven days, and prayers I prayed a year ago came to pass. Are you telling me I did not move God?"

I am telling you that you did not move God. You unstuck yourself. You dealt with the problem, the problem being the one who possessed the unbelief.

We have talked about prayer for a few nights. To tell you the truth, I would rather have stayed on it, but He would not let me. He said, "Now you have to give the brother to this sister."

Fasting is the big brother.

I said, "Lord, if fasting has that much to do with dealing with that most subtle, deceptive, horrible kind of unbelief, the kind that ceilings our lives, the kind we do not even know we have, then I am not going to get people to fast in this last decade unless I understand more about it. How can fasting deal with that kind of devastating unbelief? What does going without food have to do with anything? Is it the sacrifice that pleases You?"

No. Obedience is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams. It is not the sacrifice of starving. God would like to keep my bones fat and me happy and still answer every prayer I pray. Unfortunately, because of my background, I was not in that condition.

But fortunately, we came into some place we had never been.

Go to Romans 8:10. What does fasting have to do with unbelief?

I do not think there are any people on the face of the earth who know more about substitution and identification truths than faith people. E. W. Kenyon published his great identification books in the 1930s. Jesus was made sin as my Substitute, and I am now identified with His righteousness. He bore my sicknesses and carried my pains, and I identify with His health. He went to hell; I go to heaven.

Nobody knows more about substitution and identification truths, especially positional truths concerning my spirit man. I have been made the righteousness of God in Christ. I have been seated in heavenly places with Christ Jesus.

With Kenyon's publishing in the 1930s, Kenneth Hagin paralleling many of those truths in the 1940s and 1950s without reading Kenyon's book, and Kenneth Copeland coming on the scene as a gladiator and champion of identification, nobody knows more about these truths than us. We all dragged our little tape bags around, finding out at last that we are the righteousness of God in Christ.

Hallelujah.

But even though faith people knew more about substitution and identification truths than anyone alive, it seemed like we knew less than anyone alive about the position the flesh has been declared. It did not take long for the devil to move in and corral the camp. Pretty soon this one was running off with that one, this one was in adultery, and that one was in fornication. It just took the devil a while to corral the thing because we did not understand the position our flesh has been declared.

Meditating the Word, praying in the Holy Ghost, confessing the Word, and praying the Word all enforce the position my spirit has been declared: alive and well, seated in heavenly places with Christ Jesus.

But what about the body? What about the position it has been declared?

Romans 8:10 says:

"And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin; but the Spirit is life because of righteousness."

If Christ is in you, this is present tense. You qualify.

If the Word says it, it is so whether you put your two cents in or not. This is not a democracy. He did not ask for your vote.

If Christ is in me, my spirit is life. He did not merely say alive. My spirit is God-kind-of-life, seated in heavenly places with Christ Jesus, having entered into the express image of Jesus Christ.

In the same verse where He declared my spirit life, He declared my body dead because of sin.

It is irrelevant whether you are still wearing that body or died two hundred years ago, with your spirit dancing around heaven while your body has decayed. Positionally, the body has been declared the same: dead and waiting on the sound of the trumpet.

Someone says, "Brother Roberson, it is certainly not dead. It wants to sin and do everything else."

That is why Romans 6 says, "Reckon yourselves indeed to be dead unto sin, but alive unto God through Jesus Christ our Lord." Then it says, "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body." Why would He have to say not to let it reign if there were not a capacity for it to reign?

When He declared the body positionally dead, He said to reckon it dead indeed to sin. Although it has a capacity to sin because of what it inherited from Adam, positionally, as far as the power in it to dominate your spirit is concerned, He has given you a positional truth that says it has been rendered powerless and dead to dominate your spirit.

Praying in the Holy Ghost and meditating the Word execute the position my spirit has been declared. What executes the position of death my body has been declared concerning lusts, carnality, fears, torments, and even works of the flesh such as heresies and false doctrines?

You guessed it.

Fasting.

Fasting enforces the position your body has been declared dead concerning its dominance over your spirit. It enforces it.

If I took Louise, stuck her in an iron room where she could not eat her way out, put her on a 120-day fast on distilled water, and slipped an envelope of distilled water under her door every day, Louise would so mortify her body and put it to death that it would never bother her again. It would

never rise up in rebellion against anything the Holy Spirit was doing ever again. In fact, she would be so free from the dominance of her flesh that her inner man would be dancing through the annals of heaven with Jesus while the funeral went on down here.

The only time a man brags about fasting is when he esteems it as a sacrifice. If you do not esteem it as a sacrifice, but as something you run to because of the hunger on the inside, then you know you have found another tool that will release everything Christ is in you, the hope of glory, in a destitute, backward, and perverse generation.

The flesh will dominate your spirit with lust, greed, unbelief, carnality, strife, hatred, malice, and self-exaltation. Your poor spirit is down there dominated by all of it.

Then somebody preaches a message that injects enough hunger into you that you think, I am going to fast a few days.

When you do, the death sentence begins to set in. Mortification, the execution of positional truth, starts taking place. The dominance of the flesh begins to die. At the same time, as you pray in the Holy Ghost, your spirit rises. Prayer and fasting lock level. Then your spirit begins gaining dominance, and prayers start pouring.

I am so grateful to my Father that He has had mercy on me. I could not be a man condemned to live my life with this insatiable hunger and not know how to quench it. That is a fate worse than death, and He has had mercy on me.

Yes, fasting executes a positional truth of death. But how? How does it put the forces of the flesh to death and allow your spirit to soar?

Go to Isaiah 58, the fasting chapter.

For he that hungers and thirsts after righteousness shall be filled again and again and again. For I will pull him into Myself and feed his spirit with the heritage of Jacob, saith the Spirit of grace. I will repair their breaches and fill the empty spaces. They shall call, and I, the Lord their God, shall say, "Here I am." Nothing shall be impossible to these children of Mine, saith the Spirit of grace.

Oh, my God. Thank You, Jesus.

Isaiah 58:6 says:

"Is not this the fast that I have chosen?
to loose the bands of wickedness,
to undo the heavy burdens,
and to let the oppressed go free,
and that ye break every yoke?"

We always want to put that yoke on somebody else. But it says, "that ye break every yoke."

Then verse 7 says:

"Is it not to deal thy bread to the hungry,
and that thou bring the poor that are cast out to thy house?
when thou seest the naked, that thou cover him;
and that thou hide not thyself from thine own flesh?"

Here was the part I did not understand. I said, "Lord, I understand this is the fast You have chosen to break every yoke. But then You go on to say, Is it to deal your bread to the hungry, clothe the naked, bring the cast out into your house, and hide not yourself from your own flesh?"

I heard people teach that when you fast, you should save the money from the food you did not eat, buy clothing, clothe the naked, buy food, and feed the hungry. I used to think that was what it meant. But that is not what He is talking about, not even remotely.

He summed it up when He said, "that thou hide not thyself from thine own flesh."

When I studied the men of God who caused revival in their generations, they had one common thread running through their lives.

The late A. A. Allen became so hungry for God as an Assemblies of God pastor that he kept telling his wife, "I am going to fast." He would lock himself up because of that insatiable hunger. She would cook supper, the smell would get into the closet where he was praying, and pretty soon the door would open. He would come out, sit down, and she would feed him.

He was embarrassed to say how many times that happened. I would be embarrassed to tell you how many times I started a forty-day fast and did not finish. You need a calculator.

He did this time after time after time. Then one day he was so hungry he said, "I cannot take it anymore, wife. I am going again."

One night she cooked supper. He smelled it. He came out and sat down like usual. She set a bowl of stew in front of him. He took his spoon, put a mouthful in his mouth, began to weep, dropped the spoon, went back into the closet, and locked the door.

He did not know how long he was in there, no more than William Branham knew after he lost his family, was devastated, and had such a vacuum created in him that nobody could fill it. Branham went up into the woods after telling his wife, "If I do not come back, please understand. I must go." A little light appeared behind him about the size of a silver dollar until a full-blown angel was in his presence and gave him a mandate that changed the world.

A. A. Allen went back into the closet. He said, "I do not know how long I was in there." All of a sudden a bright light appeared in the closet, such radiance that it lit the whole closet. Then a voice spoke out of the light and began giving him a list of thirteen things to get out of his life.

He said, "Wait a minute, Lord." He got a little pencil out of his pocket. It was dull, so he sharpened it with his teeth, found a little piece of paper, and the Lord started over. He wrote those thirteen things down.

He said the first nine were easy to eradicate. Everybody did those. But the last four took him several years before he could truthfully, before God and with a clear conscience, mark them off the list.

In his testimony, I could feel the power. He said, "The night I marked the last one off, I went out and stood before the church, stood before the prayer line, and started to pray like I usually did. All of a sudden, they started going out under the power, and miracle after miracle took place."

That launched him into a worldwide ministry that shook the United States as a tent evangelist.

Thirteen things.

What does it mean to hide not yourself from your own flesh?

I said, "Jesus, does that mean I am supposed to carry on regular activities with my family and relatives, like You said in Matthew 6, to wash my face and not appear to men to be fasting so You will see and reward me openly?"

No. He was talking about when you are locked into the daily affairs of life and cannot get away. Do not use that as an excuse not to fast.

Paul commanded that if you want to separate from your wife for a time and lock yourself away for a season of fasting and prayer, that is a good thing, then come back together. So Paul advocated separation, and the Bible would not contradict itself.

So what does He mean by "hide not thyself from thine own flesh"?

Why does a missionary have to come in, set up a projector, and show you seven-year-old children dragging their two-year-old sisters through the garbage dumps of Calcutta to get you to renew your pledge? What ugly thing is it on the inside of you that will not let you clothe the naked and feed the hungry?

When He said, "hide not thyself from thine own flesh," He was saying that fasting will cause you not only to face those ugly things that will not feed the hungry and clothe the naked, but to put them to death.

Do not worry. The devil would dance with glee if you did not hear this. If you catch hold of this, you are going to trouble his kingdom.

Why do people have to come and beg? What is so carnal in us that we are indifferent?

When He commanded that you hide not yourself from your own flesh, He was saying, "This is the fast I have chosen, that you break those hideous yokes off yourself."

Do you think this city is going to heaven by itself? You are the only hope she has. You do not have the right to turn around and put the responsibility on someone else. You are her only hope.

What is it in you that does not care? Are you going to hide from your own flesh, or are you going to come face to face with it?

When I went into my first fast, I locked myself away because I did not know what to expect. I came out of it with a certain amount of glee and joy. It was great. God visited me, gave me revelation and knowledge, and I thought, This is good stuff.

After the first one, I noticed my life did not change much. I had a good time and received revelation. Then I went into another one. When I came out of it, I thought, What did I do? What did I do wrong, God? I locked myself away in fasting and prayer, and now I have come out afraid of everything. I am full of fear, intimidation, and torment. At least before, I kept it under control. Now it is at surface level.

I said, "What is the matter with me?"

It seemed like I was in such torment that I hardly got relief unless I had not even thought about going into a closet and praying. It got worse and worse. Out of pure instinct, I went into another fast. That is when something happened. Something died.

Coming out of that one, God began to minister to me. I said, "The devil really fought me on that last one."

He said, "No, that was not the devil. I was bringing out of the inside of you what you were capable of and putting it to death. You were not hiding from your own flesh, so I was putting it to death."

A preacher fasted forty days in Norway. At the end of it, he left his wife. He heard me teach and said, "Do you mean that was not the devil fighting me when I left my wife?"

He had gotten an apartment for three months before they reconciled. All of a sudden, his wife was not righteous enough. She was not perfect enough. She did not love the ministry enough. Everything was wrong with her. All he was doing was looking in a mirror.

He said, "Do you mean what I was capable of surfaced, and God was putting it to death?"

I said, "You got it, my friend. You are not going to fast forty, thirty, or twenty-one days and come out worse than you went in. The reason He pulled those deep flesh characteristics out and put them on the table was because you were never more full of the power to crucify them."

He said, "It took us three months to get back together. You mean I was capable of that the whole time?"

I said, "It is better now than when you rule over ten thousand preachers in your organization and then have that ugly thing rise up. It is better to put it to death, to face yourself, to hide not yourself from your own flesh."

Fasting will start putting the things of the flesh to death. Sometimes they do not want to die. They will kick and scream in their death throes. When you start feeling resistance, that is the time not to quit, because you are about to have the equivalency of a meltdown. Those things are going to die once and for all. You are going to remove that subtle ceiling of unbelief that has dominated your life, and your life and faith will begin to soar to the next level.

My grandpa hated my daddy. My father abandoned me when I was two. He abandoned my mother and the rest of us. He was a preacher's kid, and I did not know until I had answered the call and was preaching that my grandpa was a tent evangelist. The other side of my family told me, and I was amazed that my own father was a preacher's kid.

My grandpa hated him because he made his living robbing small gas stations and grocery stores. He was a thief. He would come running home, slit the mattress, crawl inside the mattress, and pull the cotton over him. The police would come and ransack the house, search everything, and not find him.

Grandpa hated him.

When my father abandoned us and spent most of his life in jail, we went to live with Grandpa when I was in the fourth grade. I must look like my dad, because as I grew up into my teenage years, Grandpa treated me harshly.

Grandpa was from Missouri. He would get a place, build the whole place, fences, garages, barns, and everybody worked. One day he would be holding a board and say, "Get me that hammer." Because I knew what was coming, pressure would hit me and I could not see it. There might have been nothing else on the table but a hammer, but I could not see it.

The longer it took me to see it, the louder he screamed until I panicked. Then he would come charging over, throw the board down, cuss me, and kick me so hard my teeth rattled.

That instilled some kind of fear and intimidation in me toward authority. Even when God began to exalt me, He could not take me any further into peace. Even when I stood on the platform with some of the world's greatest evangelists, I was so intimidated that I would always be jostling for their approval: Please throw me a little tidbit. Make me feel like I have done okay.

When I went through that last seeking time, I did not know what was wrong. Torment, fear, and ungodly pressure came. I did not know He was putting those things to death and they were kicking in their death throes.

I came out on the other side and could only explain what I had as the most unsettling peace I did not know could exist. I finally labeled it aggressive peace.

It does not matter what God calls me to do, the size of the revival, what city I am in, or whether I am sitting in a jail cell. If you have that kind of peace, you are unmanageable by the devil.

I came out of that thing with peace, and God pulled me into that room and started talking to me, teaching me some things we have been talking about today. He said:

"Did you know nobody can intimidate you or hurt you unless you give them the authority to do it?"

I thought, I have been so stupid.

My goal is to somehow turn you over to the Holy Ghost so He can turn you over to Jesus until you become so complete in Him that your dependency is not on man but on Him. They can put you in a coal mine in Siberia, and you can smile and say, "I am complete in Him. He is my sufficiency."

Why? Because fasting executes the positional truth your body has been declared. It puts to death the carnal forces of the flesh: lusts, fears, intimidation, cares, and heresies.

Let us see what Jesus said. Go to Matthew 9:14:

"Then came to him the disciples of John, saying, Why do we and the Pharisees fast oft, but thy disciples fast not?"

Jesus answered in verse 15:

"Can the children of the bridechamber mourn, as long as the bridegroom is with them? but the days will come, when the bridegroom shall be taken from them, and then shall they fast."

Jesus was saying, "I am the Head of the Church. I am with you. You are My disciples. I am the Bridegroom. The anointing is on Me. But the day will come that I will be taken away."

Then notice what He said: "Then shall they fast."

He did not say maybe, if possible, if they felt like it, sometime in the future if the opportunity arose. He said, "My disciples in that day shall fast."

A disciple is a disciplined follower.

Here is the part I did not understand. Jesus was still answering their question in Matthew 9:16-17:

"No man putteth a piece of new cloth unto an old garment, for that which is put in to fill it up taketh from the garment, and the rent is made worse.

Neither do men put new wine into old bottles: else the bottles break, and the wine runneth out, and the bottles perish:

but they put new wine into new bottles, and both are preserved."

That is very good, except what does it have to do with fasting?

They asked, "John's disciples fast often, but Your disciples do not fast at all." Jesus said, "I am the anointing. I am here. As long as I am with them, they do not need to fast. But the day will come when I am taken away. Then they will fast."

Then He said, "No man puts new wine in old bottles."

For years I heard preachers explain it as, "A person has to be born again before he can receive the wine of the Holy Spirit. You cannot put new wine in an old wineskin. You have to be born again before you can receive the baptism."

That is funny. Poor Jesus. On both sides of those two verses, He teaches about fasting, and then suddenly stops to say, "Look, you have to be saved to get the Holy Ghost." Tremendous, Jesus. That is deep.

So what was He saying?

For six years that verse was lodged in my spirit, ever since my days in Medford. I passed through it and said, "What does it mean?" I asked those who seemed to be something among them, and they gave me the usual answer. But when it finally came forth, my spirit understood it first. My brain was too carnal to analyze it. I knew it in here, but I could not get it out.

When the Daystar rose in my quiet place after peace, I could articulate it.

If Christ is in you, the body has been declared dead because of sin. You are still wearing a body given to you by the first Adam, not the last Adam, Christ Jesus. That is why it is capable of sinning. He said, "Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal body."

Even though I am wearing a body given by the first Adam, an old wineskin and an old garment, I possess a spirit that has entered into zoe, God-kind-of-life, and is seated in my heavenly place with Christ Jesus.

Jesus said, "When I am gone, in that day you will fast, for no man puts new wine in an old bottle." A man goes out and gets a new wineskin because it can sustain the fermenting process.

You fast for the same reason: fasting fortifies the vessel and puts to death what would break under the power. It causes the power to be sustained within.

You fast for the same reason a man does not put a new patch on an old garment. A new patch is strong, and if you sew it onto an old rotten garment, it will tear away at the seams and make the rip worse.

Fasting sustains the old wineskin and causes it to be as though it were new, able to sustain the power. It puts to death everything that would destroy the precious anointing, cause the wineskin to burst, and spill out the wine.

It sustains the old wineskin so that it does not burst.